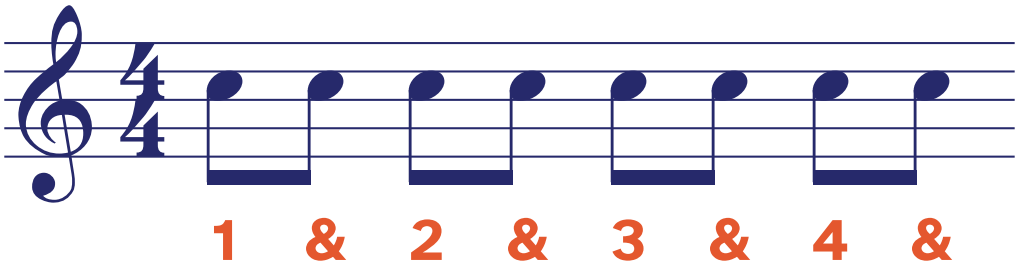
PART II · TIME · 6

Rhythm: groups and upbeats

Say your own name: long and short sounds, that's **rhythm**. The pulse marches steadily on; the rhythm dances around it. How the notes are grouped on the page shows where the beats fall.

THE SECRET

Beams group notes into beats; an upbeat borrows from the last bar.



One beam, one beat

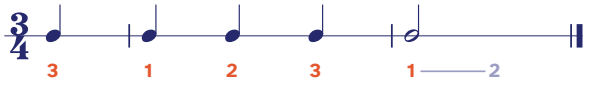
Grouping with beams

Beams join the notes of **one beat**, so the beats stay visible. In 4/4 a beam may cover beats 1–2 or 3–4, but never cross the middle of the bar (except in a deliberate grouping such as 3 + 3 + 2). In compound time, quavers are beamed in threes.

× A beam across beats 2 and 3 would hide the middle of the bar.

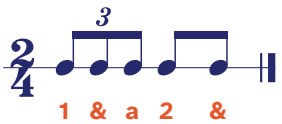
The upbeat (anacrusis)

A piece can begin **before** the first full bar, with one or more notes called an upbeat or anacrusis. The last bar is then short by the same amount, so the two together make one full bar. Count the missing beats in silence before you start.
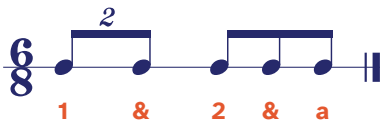


Count "1 2" silently, then play on 3.

Triplets and duplets



Triplet: three exactly equal notes in the time of two. First met: Level 2.



Duplet: two notes in the time of three, in compound time. First met: Level 2.

PART II · TIME · 6 · CONTINUED



Two quavers: one beat cut in 2



A **triplet**: one beat cut in 3



Four semiquavers: one beat cut in 4

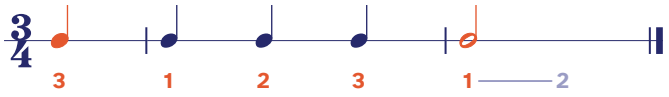
Counting smaller values



Crotchet, two quavers, four semiquavers and a triplet (“1 & a”): one beat each.

EXAMPLE 1

Balance the upbeat



1. **The upbeat:** one beat (count 3) before the first full bar.
2. **The last bar:** only two beats.
3. **Add them:** 1 + 2 = 3, one whole bar of 3/4.

The upbeat and the last bar **make one full bar** together.

GAME

May the beam join them?

1	2	3
beats 1 and 2	beats 2 and 3	beats 3 and 4

In 4/4, quavers are beamed so the middle of the bar stays visible. Which pairs may share one beam?

Answer: 1 yes · 2 no, that hides the middle of the bar · 3 yes.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
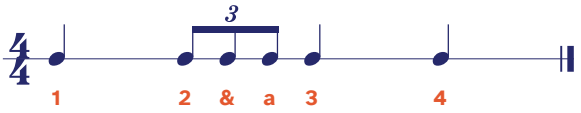


Clap “1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &”.

Now clap only the numbers, then only the &s, while your foot keeps the beat. The beat never moves; your claps do.

PART II · TIME · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Fit a triplet into a bar

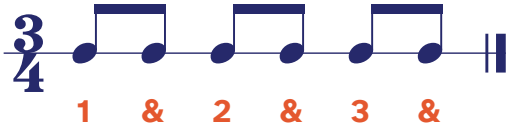


1. **Count the bar:** four crotchet beats, “1 2 3 4”.
2. **Find the 3:** on beat 2, three quavers share one beat.
3. **Say it:** “1, 2 & a, 3, 4”, keeping beats 3 and 4 steady.

The triplet squeezes three notes into **beat 2**; the beat itself never moves.

EXAMPLE 3

Beam six quavers in 3/4



1. **3/4 has three beats,** each a crotchet.
2. **Each beat** holds two quavers.
3. **So the beams go 2 + 2 + 2.** Grouped 3 + 3 they would look like 6/8.

In 3/4, six quavers are beamed **in twos**.
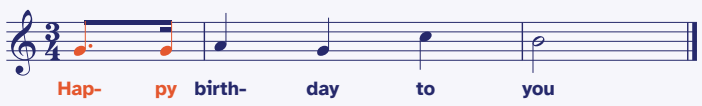
HOW TO

Practise triplets

1. **Say “trip-o-let”** on every beat, evenly.
2. **Clap the three syllables** while your foot keeps the beat.
3. **Switch** between two quavers (“1 &”) and a triplet (“trip-o-let”) every bar.

YOU KNOW THIS

Happy Birthday



“Hap-py” comes **before** the first strong beat: an upbeat. The strong beat lands on “birth”.

Try it. Sing it and clap only on “birth”, “day” and “you”: you feel where bar 1 starts.

THINK OF IT An upbeat is the breath before you speak: “and-ONE”. You lift on the upbeat so the strong beat can land.

SEE ALSO
Notes and rests p. 49 · Rhythm: off the beat p. 65

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Levels ½–4 · Rhythm · Online: Rhythm clock